

GATORBAIT

M A G A Z I N E

REAL
STORIES
BIGGER
PERSPECTIVE.

HOME COMING TEST

No. 16 Florida
Hosts
South Carolina

BAUGH OWNS IT

Florida RB
Answers the
Missouri Loss

FRANZ BEARD

Rain Could Turn
Homecoming
Into a Mud Bowl

BUDDY MARTIN

The Balm of
Homecoming

EDDIE GILLEY

Florida Gave
Way Too Much

REBOUND AT THE SWAMP

TRADITION
RESILIENCE
THE NEXT CHAPTER

THE GAME

UNRANKED SOUTH CAROLINA

2-3-0-3 SEC

AT

NO. 16 FLORIDA

4-1-2-1 SEC

Saturday, Oct. 10 • 12:45 p.m. ET • SEC Network

Ben Hill Griffin Stadium, Gainesville. Florida's Homecoming

35% chance of rain before 2 p.m., 83% after; 82-85°, SE wind 15 mph, gusts to 22 (NWS forecast, Oct. 8)

LINE

Florida -11.5

TOTAL

59.5

SERIES

UF leads 31-10-3

ESPN MATCHUP PREDICTOR

Florida 73.1%

ESPN game summary and pickcenter (DraftKings), Oct. 8. Forecast: NWS Jacksonville, Oct. 8.

FOUR KEYS

1. Stopping the SEC's top run game

South Carolina runs for 256.0 yards a game, No. 1 in the SEC and No. 7 nationally, at 6.5 a carry. Matt Fuller has 433 yards and 6.1 a carry; LaNorris Sellers has 391 and leads the SEC at 7.4. Florida held its first four opponents to 3.4 a carry, then Missouri ran 36 times for 220.

2. Turnovers

South Carolina has eight giveaways and two takeaways, a minus-6 margin that ranks No. 130 nationally in turnovers gained. Opponents have scored 34 points off Gamecock turnovers, and two lost fumbles set up 10 Kentucky points in last week's overtime loss. South Carolina is 1-3 when it loses the turnover battle.

3. Philo vs. the No. 125 pass defense

South Carolina's opponents have completed 65.8% for 1,156 yards, 13 touchdowns and two interceptions, No. 125 in FBS in pass efficiency defense. Aaron Philo is 84 of 121 for 1,114 yards, eight touchdowns and two interceptions, but Florida managed 5.8 yards an attempt when it had to throw from behind at Missouri.

4. The weather and the field

The NWS puts the rain chance at 35% through 2 p.m. and 83% after, with about a third of an inch from 2 to 8 p.m. and a 33% chance of thunder from 2 to 5. Heat index 98 at 2 p.m., southeast wind 15 mph with gusts to 22. Lightning within 8 miles suspends play for at least 30 minutes.

South Carolina game notes and flip card, Week 6; ESPN box scores: NWS Jacksonville, Oct. 8; SEC severe weather policy as quoted by the UAA.

TALE OF THE TAPE

Five games, per game, from South Carolina's team comparison

	FLORIDA	S. CAROLINA
Points scored	46.2	37.6
Total yards	491.2	491
Rushing yards	216.4	256
Yards a carry	5.4	6.5
Passing yards	274.8	235
Points allowed	27.2	26.8
Rush yards allowed	126.4	100.4
Pass yards allowed	266.6	231.2
Third down %	46	44
Opp. third down %	43	35
Possession(minutes)	32.9	29.3

South Carolina game notes, Week 6 (team comparison)

THE SERIES

EIGHT OF THE LAST 12

Florida leads 31-10-3 and is 17-2 in Gainesville, where South Carolina's last win was 23-20 in overtime in 2014. The Gators have won the last two: 38-6 in The Swamp in 2022 and 41-39 in Columbia in 2023, when they scored twice in the final 4:40.

AVAILABILITY

ESPN lists no injuries for either team as of Thursday, Oct. 8. The official SEC availability report posts Thursday night and again before kickoff on FloridaGators.com.

NOSTALGIA IS WONDERFUL. IT CANNOT PICK UP A BLITZ.

BY BUDDY MARTIN Oct. 8, 2026



Photo Courtesy of UAA

"A 12.5 SPREAD IS AN OPINION, NOT A RESTRAINING ORDER."

Just under a two-touchdown favorite, an upset alert and a forecast only a Gator could love.

By Buddy Martin

Florida is 12.5-point favorite over South Carolina in The Rebound Bowl, which ought to make homecoming a pleasant occasion for renewing old friendships, applauding old heroes and wondering why your old parking spot now requires a second mortgage.

Provided Florida understands the difference between hosting a celebration and participating in one. South Carolina has not been invited down to admire the decorations.

Instead, the Gators seem to be on upset alert. Only in college football can you be favored by 12.5 and still feel obligated to check the back door.

The betting line says Florida should handle this. The little voice in the back of the Gator fan's head says the betting line won't be sitting beside him if things go sideways.

That voice has attended a few games, too.

The weather forecast doesn't look particularly good. The football forecast could be splendid.

There are plenty of inducements. All gates for Saturday's homecoming football game between Florida and South Carolina will open two hours before kickoff at 10:45 a.m., the University Athletic Association has announced.

Also, all concessions in the stadium will be 50-percent off from 10:45-11:45 a.m.

Which almost brings it back to normal!

This will be the 500th game in The Swamp.

Five hundred.

That is a lot of Saturdays, a lot of sweat, a lot of bad officiating witnessed exclusively by the home crowd. A lot of young men growing old in photographs while the people who watched them insist they remember every play.

And some of them do.

At the end of the first quarter, Steve Spurrier will have two minutes to acknowledge members of his 1996 national championship team and his 1966 teammates — the ones still here to answer the roll call.

There is your homecoming.

Not the souvenir shirt. Not the hospitality tent. Not somebody explaining how much better everything was when he was an undergraduate and somebody else was paying.

Those men.

The youngsters who helped build something before anybody knew what it would become. The champions who finally delivered what generations of Florida fans had been accused of imagining.

Spurrier connects them. The quarterback who won Florida's first Heisman Trophy in 1966 became the coach who brought home its first national championship 30 years later. That is not merely a résumé. That is a considerable portion of the family history.

Two minutes will hardly cover it.

"I won't have time to say much," Spurrier told me. He did want to thank Jeremy Foley, his staff, school president Kent Fuchs and the UAA board of directors and board of trustees.

Of course, Spurrier has always been capable of accomplishing quite a bit before the other fellow gets organized.

He has called having the field named for him "the greatest honor I ever received" — even better than winning the Heisman Trophy.

When the naming was announced, his public statement called it "the biggest, most special honor I have ever received."

Think about that.

The Heisman made him the best player in the country.

The name on the field made him part of the address.

Long after the last person who saw him play has gone, some father will explain that name to some child walking into the stadium for the first time.

And if the father gets carried away, they may miss kickoff.

Spurrier didn't merely win here. He changed what people expected here. Six SEC championships and that national title will do that to a place. So will a 122-27-1 coaching record, with only 7 losses in 89 appearances as a player or coach on the field that was named after him.

Before him, Florida fans could turn next year into a religious observance.

He made this year worth discussing.

Now he will stand on the field bearing his name and recognize men from two teams separated by 30 years, joined by a lifetime of orange and blue.

Even a cynic ought to take his hat off for that.

Then Florida needs to get back to work.

Nostalgia is wonderful. It cannot pick up a blitz.

A 12.5 spread is an opinion, not a restraining order. It does not keep South Carolina out of the end zone. It does not prevent a dropped pass, a foolish penalty or the sort of turnover that makes 90,000 people suddenly remember an urgent reason to sit down.

The Gators can make this a splendid football afternoon. They can give the returning champions something to applaud besides one another.

But they ought to approach it with the understanding that homecoming opponents have a deplorable habit of wanting to win.

Nobody ever arrived in Gainesville saying, "We're just happy to help with the anniversary."

And South Carolina has its own chapter in the Spurrier story. The man being celebrated once coached the Gamecocks to their first victory in The Swamp and an SEC East championship. Sentiment has never been much of a defensive scheme.

So honor the old Gators.

Listen to the Head Ball Coach.

Remember what those teams accomplished, and what it took.

Then make the visitors uncomfortable.

The skies may open. The ponchos may come out. The expensive shoes may lose an argument with the weather.

None of that has to spoil homecoming.

Rain is manageable.

Having to explain how a big favorite lost the 500th game in its own Swamp would be a considerably longer afternoon.

THE LEAD • FRANZ BEARD

FLORIDA VS SOUTH CAROLINA: RAIN COULD TURN HOMECOMING INTO A MUD BOWL

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 8, 2026



GatorBait Media file photo

The rain in Spain may indeed fall mainly on the plain, but Saturday there is a very good chance the rain in Gainesville will fall on Ben Hill Griffin Stadium, which could turn the Gators' game with South Carolina into a slip sliding wet grass mess. The latest out of Las Vegas has 16th-ranked Florida (4-1, 2-1 SEC) favored by 11.5 points against a South Carolina (2-3, 0-3 SEC) team still reeling from last week blowing a 17-0 lead and losing to Kentucky in overtime.

The visiting Gamecocks don't lack for talent, especially on offense. The numbers bear that out. South Carolina ranks third in the SEC in total offense — 491 yards per game, 256 on the ground and 235 through the air — but the Gamecocks struggle to put teams away. However, the Florida defense the Gamecocks will face is coming off a game in which Missouri threw for 340 yards and ran for 220 while lighting up the scoreboard for 45 points. South Carolina offensive coordinator Kendal Briles has to see this as an opportunity for the Gamecocks to move the ball and put points on the board.

This is where the rain might come into play in a frustrating way for the Gators. South Carolina does run the football well, which typically is a necessity for winning in rainy conditions with a soggy field. Complicating matters for the Florida defense is quarterback LaNorris Sellers, who is averaging 7.38 yards on designed runs and scrambles.

Can the Florida defense contain the running game and keep Sellers in the pocket?

"When he [Sellers] gets out of the pocket he's really dangerous," Florida defensive coordinator Brad White said. "You saw the run against Kentucky when they had him for a sack in the backfield. He escapes and then he goes for 70-whatever to set up a score."

Sellers' dual threat ability makes running back Matt Fuller even more dangerous. He's run for 433 yards (6.1 per carry). Backup Jabree Coleman is a breakaway threat who averages 8.65 per carry. These guys on a field made slick by the rain will be a challenge, particularly if South Carolina can get the lead and then play keep away by running the ball down the Gators' throats.

The Gators proved in SEC wins over Auburn and Ole Miss that they are very good when they have the lead. The rain that could benefit South Carolina's run game could have the same effect on Florida.

And, this is the type of game where getting the lead and holding it with the run could be the key to winning. The odds of Florida winning are much greater if the Gators can pick and choose when to throw because they've got the running game going.

If UF is behind and forced to throw, things could be a bit dicey. When the Gators fell behind Missouri last week and were put in a must throw situation, they performed rather poorly. Aaron Philo struggled to find receivers open downfield, so the dink and dunk approach was good for only 5.8 yards per pass attempt. It's rare to win games when averaging less than 7.0 yards per attempt against SEC defenses.

"We've got to be able to run football," Florida offensive coordinator Buster Faulkner said. "It was kind of the way the [Missouri] game unfolded. Probably got away from it in the second half when you get down. We're not built for that right now, right?"

Throwing the ball will be a necessity as well, but if the Gators can get Jadan Baugh and Duke Clark untracked in the running game, it will allow Faulkner to pick and choose when he wants Philo passing. It has been raining all week in Gainesville, so Philo has had opportunities to work with a wet ball in practice.

"The good thing is we've got rain early this week and you just go out in the rain and do it," Faulkner said.

INJURY REPORT

South Carolina: DB Jalewis Solomon, WR Jayden Sellers, EDGE Koby Sakyi-Prah and OL Josiah Thompson out; WR Mazeo Bennett Jr. and OL Carter Miller questionable; and DB Quay'sheed Scott, EDGE Julian Walker and DL Gabriel Brownlow-Dindy doubtful.

FLORIDA: WR Vernell Brown III and RB/KR London Montgomery questionable; S Bryce Thornton and CB Dijon Johnson probable.

COUNTDOWN TO FIRING DAY: OCTOBER 8, 2026 EDITION

EXTINCT SPECIES LIST

A lot of nervous people in Columbia, South Carolina. Stay tuned if South Carolina goes belly up in Gainesville.

ON LIFE SUPPORT

Shane Beamer, South Carolina: The knock on Beamer is he beats the non-conference teams he's supposed to beat then goes into the tank against the SEC. The hire of Kendal Briles has done wonders for the offense, but the defense stinks and the Beamers are 0-3 in SEC play. A Saturday loss combined with the schedule that is ahead spells the end of Beamer Ball in South Carolina, maybe as early as this weekend if the loss to the Gators is a blowout.

Mike Norvell, Florida State: There is bad news and here is bad news for FSU. First the bad news. The Seminoles could actually beat Louisville which could be playing without its starting QB. Now for the really bad news, a win will make the Seminoles 4-2 which gets Norvell closer to you can't touch me territory. Six or seven wins combined with his buyout means Norvell is close to untouchable status for the remainder of this year. They want Norvell gone. The bad news is he's liable to get to six or seven wins and force Richmond to keep him at least around another year.

Dave Doeren, North Carolina State: The Wolfpack are 3-2 and the next three are all winnable games. Doeren's history is 7-5 or 8-5. The fans want championships not another trip to scenic Birmingham or Shreveport.

Mike Locksley, Maryland: The last thing a coach whose team has lost three straight and has given up 102 points combined in the last two is a trip to the Horseshoe. After Ohio State delivers a ritual beatdown Saturday odds are that Locks won't be the head coach of the Turtles on Monday.

Greg Schiano, Rutgers: The good news is Rutgers cannot lose this week but that's only because it's an open date. Next week the Scarlet Knights travel to Maryland, where they might be facing a team with a brand new head coach. It's probably the last chance Rutgers (1-4) has a chance to win. Schiano is actually a good coach, but Rutgers is the football equivalent of a toxic waste dump.

Bill O'Brien, Boston College: The Eagles are 2-3. That's the good news. The bad news is any win from here on out will be a major upset. OB is a good coach, but like Schiano at Rutgers, he's coaching at a place that is light years beyond the reach of the living. No chance of losing this week. Open date.

Bill Belichick, North Carolina: For three quarters the Fighting Belichicks had a chance against mighty Notre Dame. Unfortunately games last four quarters and by the time the final 15 minutes rolled around UNC was gassed. The Tar Heels are 2-2 and a 6-win season is do-able. That might keep the boosters from demanding a new coach.

Dell McGee, Georgia State: The Panthers are off to a surprising 4-1 start and they're averaging 39 points per game. There are two or three winnable games on the remaining schedule. A 7-5 record certainly seals the deal that he will be back next year, but 6-6 could do it.

Deion Sanders, Colorado: Prime Time is always good for sound bites and attention. The folks in Colorado wish he was good for more wins. The Buffs are 2-3 with three straight losses. Next two are Utah and (at) Oklahoma State. Once the record goes to 2-5, the clock starts ticking for Deion.

Dave Aranda, Baylor: Here's a shocker for you. DJ Lagway threw four TD passes last week without an interception. The Bears have won four straight and they have a week off to get ready for TCU, which is struggling. There are at least three very winnable games on the schedule. If DJ can remember to throw to people wearing the same color shirt as he's wearing, the Bears could easily get to eight wins this year. DJ couldn't save a coaching job last year, but he might save Dave Aranda's.

Lincoln Riley, Southern Cal: Yes, the Trojans are 5-1, but it's the same old, same old for every Riley-coached team. They can score points and lots of them. They can give up points and lots of them. The faithful believe the Trojans should be in the hunt for a national title every year, so they are growing weary of Riley's all offense, no defense approach.

Butch Jones, Arkansas State: If Butch can find a way to get the Red Wolves to a fourth straight bowl game and maybe a third straight bowl win, the faithful will be happy. Jonesboro, Arkansas isn't exactly the garden spot of the earth so winning seasons, even the 7-6 type, should be celebrated.

Brent Venables, Oklahoma: Yes, they gave him a contract extension but that was when folks thought the Sooners were going to have an offense capable of scoring points against an all-star team from a convent. It's unlikely he gets canned this year, but it's possible if the Sooners go in the tank. There is no Plan B for the offense.

ENDANGERED SPECIES LIST

Dabo Swinney, Clemson: The folks at IPTAY aren't happy campers, but unless they take out their brains every evening to play with them, they'll do their best to let Dabo leave Clemson on his own terms. He's 10 wins away from 200. Once he gets to 200, he's fair game to be fired or to announce he's riding off into the sunset.

SATURDAY IN THE SEC

Kickoffs and TV: SEC Week 6 release. All times ET. Florida's line from ESPN.

TIME (ET)	GAME	TV	LINE
Noon	Texas A&M (3-2) at No. 14 Missouri (4-1)	ABC	
12:45 p.m.	South Carolina (2-3) at No. 16 Florida (4-1) Homecoming	SEC Network	FLA -11.5 • O/U 59.5
3:30 p.m.	Oklahoma (3-2) at No. 1 Texas (4-0) Cotton Bowl, Dallas	ABC	
3:30 p.m.	No. 9 Ole Miss (3-1) at Vanderbilt (3-2)	ESPN	
4:15 p.m.	No. 15 Tennessee (4-1) at Arkansas (2-3)	SEC Network	
7 p.m.	No. 10 LSU (4-1) at Kentucky (4-1)	ESPN	
7:30 p.m.	No. 2 Georgia (5-0) at No. 6 Alabama (5-0)	ABC	

Kickoffs, TV and records: SEC Week 6 release. Rankings: AP poll, as listed in the release. Florida line and total: ESPN pickcenter (DraftKings).

HOW TO WATCH

KICKOFF	Saturday, Oct. 10, 12:45 p.m. ET
TV	SEC Network
STREAM	ESPN app, with a TV-provider login
RADIO	Gator IMG Sports Network, with Sean Kelley
GATES	All gates open at 10:45 a.m.; concessions half off until 11:45 a.m.
WHERE	Ben Hill Griffin Stadium, Gainesville. Florida's Homecoming and the 500th game in The Swamp

Sources: ESPN broadcast listing; FloridaGators.com radio network and gates release; 500th game per Buddy Martin's column.

SOUTH CAROLINA WEEK

FRANZ BEARD • THE SOOTHSAYER

THE SOOTHSAYER: GATORS WILL HANDLE ADVERSITY AND BOUNCE BACK BIG

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 9, 2026

GATORS WILL HANDLE ADVERSITY AND BOUNCE BACK BIG

Missouri was a punch to the gut. Homecoming against South Carolina is the answer. The Sayer says Florida wins by two touchdowns or more.

Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

Adversity and football go hand in hand. You can't have one without the other, not in this game. Everybody gets knocked down. It's how teams react after taking a punch to the gut or a fist to the face that separates the good teams from the bad ones. And, even though it's just midyear and there is plenty of football to be played, it's never too early to have a game that separates contenders from pretenders.

So what are the Florida Gators (4-1, 2-1 SEC)? Are they contenders? Those wins over Auburn and Ole Miss had the whole wide world thinking so. Why some folks were daring to think the Gators could challenge for the national championship after those back-to-back showings. Or are the Gators pretenders? That loss to Missouri was dog's butt ugly. Florida left CoMo looking like a team that might struggle to get to seven wins, not like one that could make the College Football Playoff and win a game or two.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/the-soothsayer-gators-will-handle-adversity-and-bounce-back-big

South Carolina (2-3, 0-3 SEC) comes to Gainesville Saturday (12:45 p.m., SEC Network) in desperate need of a win to save head ball coach Shane Beamer from being skewered and rotisserie'd over an oakwood fire. The Gamecocks are likely to show up hair on fire and ready to spring an upset over the nation's No. 16 team. How Florida responds will tell us a lot about what to expect the second half of the season.

THE BUDDY MARTIN SHOW

BUDDY MARTIN SHOW: CAN THE GATORS BOUNCE BACK WITH A HOMECOMING WIN?

BY BRENDEN MARTIN Oct. 9, 2026



The Buddy Martin Show

Missouri hit Florida in the mouth. The question on Thursday night's edition of The Buddy Martin Show: do the Gators punch back?

South Carolina visits Saturday for the 500th game in The Swamp, where Florida is 17-2 against the Gamecocks. The only home losses came in 2010 and 2014. History favors the Gators, and so does the line. None of it means a thing unless Jon Sumrall's team delivers the right response.

Buddy Martin, Franz Beard, Ben Troupe and Eddie Gilley break down what to expect at Homecoming and what Florida has to prove.

Watch: Can the Gators Bounce Back With Homecoming Win? on YouTube

Read more:

- Franz Beard: Gators will handle adversity and bounce back big
- Buddy Martin: Checking out the point spread and weather for Gator Homecoming
- Gators Homecoming guide: parade, Hall of Fame, Growl

The Buddy Martin Show streams live on YouTube and Facebook. Mondays, Wednesdays and Thursdays at 9 p.m. ET.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/buddy-martin-show-can-the-gators-bounce-back-with-a-homecoming-win

BRENDEN MARTIN • NEWS

FLORIDA'S 2-1 SEC START MEETS 0-3 SOUTH CAROLINA AT HOMECOMING

BY BRENDEN MARTIN Oct. 8, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

No. 16 Florida in the AP poll hosts South Carolina on Saturday, Oct. 10, in Homecoming. The Gators (4-1) are 2-1 in the SEC after a 45-17 loss at Missouri on Oct. 3. South Carolina is 0-3 in league play. Kickoff is 12:45 p.m. ET on SEC Network at Ben Hill Griffin Stadium.

THE SERIES

Florida leads the series 31-10-3, according to South Carolina's game notes and the SEC's Week 6 release. The notes say the first meeting was a 6-6 tie on Oct. 21, 1911, and Saturday is the 45th. They list the Gators at 17-2 in Gainesville, where South Carolina's last win was 23-20 in overtime on Nov. 15, 2014. Florida holds an 8-6 edge in the last 14 meetings, according to the notes.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/florida-s-2-1-sec-start-meets-0-3-south-carolina-at-homecoming

The last meeting was Florida 41, South Carolina 39, on Oct. 14, 2023, in Columbia. The notes say the Gators scored two touchdowns in the final 4:40 to erase a 10-point fourth-quarter deficit, and Graham Mertz hit Ricky Pearsall for a 21-yard touchdown with 47 seconds left. Florida also won 38-6 in The Swamp on Nov. 12, 2022, according to the notes. South Carolina's notes list the 2023 game as the most recent meeting, so the Gators have won the last two.

SOUTH CAROLINA IS 0-3 IN THE SEC, BUT TWO LOSSES WERE ONE-SCORE GAMES

BY BRENDEN MARTIN Oct. 8, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

South Carolina comes to Gainesville 0-3 in the SEC, and two of those losses were decided by a combined eight points. No. 16 Florida in the AP poll (4-1, 2-1 SEC) hosts the Gamecocks (2-3) Saturday at 12:45 p.m. ET on SEC Network. The record is a poor guide to how South Carolina has played.

THE MARGINS

Mississippi State beat South Carolina 41-34 on Sept. 19. Alabama won 49-18 on Sept. 26, and that one was not close. Kentucky followed on Oct. 3 with a 35-34 overtime win at Williams-Brice Stadium.

South Carolina's game notes say the Gamecocks led Kentucky 17-0 before the Wildcats scored 10 points late in the first half. In overtime, LaNorris Sellers threw a 5-yard touchdown pass to Maurice Brown II for a 34-27 lead. Kentucky scored and converted a two-point try to win. According to ESPN's box score, South Carolina outgained Kentucky 458 yards to 394. The notes say two lost fumbles led to 10 Kentucky points.

TURNOVERS

The turnover trouble is not limited to Kentucky. According to South Carolina's game notes, the Gamecocks have eight giveaways (four interceptions and four lost fumbles) against two takeaways, a turnover margin of minus 6, or minus 1.2 a game. Opponents have scored 34 points off South Carolina turnovers, and South Carolina has scored 14 off theirs. The notes list South Carolina at 1-3 when it commits more turnovers than its opponent, and No. 130 nationally in turnovers gained.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/south-carolina-is-0-3-in-the-sec-but-two-losses-were-one-score-games

BRENDEN MARTIN • NEWS

SOUTH CAROLINA BRINGS THE SEC'S TOP RUSHING OFFENSE TO GAINESVILLE

BY BRENDEN MARTIN Oct. 8, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

No. 16 Florida in the AP poll faces the SEC's top rushing offense Saturday at 12:45 p.m. ET on SEC Network. South Carolina averages 256.0 rushing yards a game, No. 1 in the SEC and No. 7 nationally, according to South Carolina's game notes. Florida comes in after a game on Oct. 3 in which it allowed 220 rushing yards and gained 42.

WHAT HAPPENED AT MISSOURI

Missouri rushed 36 times for 220 yards, 6.1 a carry, in a 45-17 win, according to ESPN's box score. Jamal Roberts had 24 carries for 211 yards, three touchdowns and an 80-yard run. ESPN's box score shows Florida with 25 rushing attempts for 42 yards, 1.7 a carry. Jadan Baugh had 12 carries for 13 yards.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/south-carolina-brings-the-sec-s-top-rushing-offense-to-gainesville

Florida's first four opponents rushed for 412 yards on 120 carries, 3.4 a carry, according to ESPN's box scores: Florida Atlantic 120, Campbell 62, Auburn 102 and Ole Miss 128. Missouri was the exception at 6.1. With that game included, South Carolina's game notes list Florida's opponents at 126.4 rushing yards a game and 4.1 a carry. By GatorBait's calculation from the box scores, Missouri's 220 yards are 220 of the 632 Florida has allowed on the ground this season.

GATORS HOMECOMING GUIDE: PARADE, HALL OF FAME, GROWL

BY BRENDEN MARTIN Oct. 8, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

Florida's Homecoming weekend starts Friday, Oct. 9, and ends with a sold-out Swamp on Saturday, when the Gators host South Carolina at 12:45 p.m. ET. Here is what the University of Florida and the University Athletic Association have confirmed so far, event by event.

FRIDAY: PARADE AND CAMPUS FESTIVAL

The Homecoming Parade is set for noon Friday. Organizers bill it as the largest student-run parade in the nation. It begins at 13th Street and Museum Road, heads north and turns onto University Avenue, then continues to Bo Diddley Plaza on Main Street. The route was adjusted this year to account for the speed tables on University Avenue.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/gators-homecoming-guide-parade-hall-of-fame-growl

The Campus Festival is also listed for Friday at the Plaza of the Americas. Its hours were not posted on the official Homecoming site, so check the schedule before you go.

FRIDAY NIGHT: GATOR GROWL AND THE HALL OF FAME

Gator Growl, which the Homecoming organizers call the crown jewel of the celebration, is Friday at the Stephen C. O'Connell Center. Tickets are sold through the Gator Growl website, and the start time is still to be confirmed by UF.

The UF Athletic Hall of Fame will also welcome eight new members Friday. The Class of 2026 is:

SWAMP GAMEDAY GUIDE: RAIN ODDS CLIMB AFTER 2 P.M.

BY BRENDEN MARTIN Oct. 8, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

Florida (4-1, No. 16) and South Carolina kick off Homecoming at 12:45 p.m. Saturday at Ben Hill Griffin Stadium on the SEC Network. The game is scheduled as planned. Moisture from Hurricane Isaias is headed toward North Florida, and the National Weather Service is forecasting a wet afternoon.

All forecast details below are as of 3 p.m. ET Thursday, Oct. 8. Conditions can change, so check again Saturday morning.

THE FORECAST, HOUR BY HOUR

The NWS Jacksonville office puts the chance of showers and thunderstorms in Gainesville at 35 percent from 8 a.m. to 2 p.m. Saturday. That window includes kickoff. It forecasts no measurable rain in that block.

At 2 p.m., about 75 minutes into the game, the chance jumps to 83 percent. It stays there until 8 p.m. The NWS expects about a third of an inch of rain from 2 to 8 p.m. and puts the chance of thunder at 33 percent from 2 to 5 p.m.

Temperatures run 82 degrees at noon, 84 at 1 p.m. and 85 at 2 p.m., falling to 83 by 4 p.m. The heat index is forecast at 92 at noon and 98 at 2 p.m. Winds are out of the southeast around 15 mph, with gusts up to 22 mph.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/swamp-gameday-guide-rain-odds-climb-after-2-p-m

GATORS-GAMECOCKS SELLS OUT; DOERING NAMED SEC LEGEND

BY BRENDEN MARTIN Oct. 8, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

Saturday's Homecoming game between Florida and South Carolina is sold out, the university announced Thursday. It is the 22nd straight sellout at Ben Hill Griffin Stadium. Kickoff is 12:45 p.m.

The streak is the longest for the Gators since they sold out 138 consecutive games from 1989 to 2011. Florida's ticket office announced last month that student season tickets were sold out. Single-game tickets remain on sale only for home games against Oklahoma on Nov. 7 and Vanderbilt on Nov. 21. Ticketmaster.com is the only authorized seller of Florida Gators verified resale tickets.

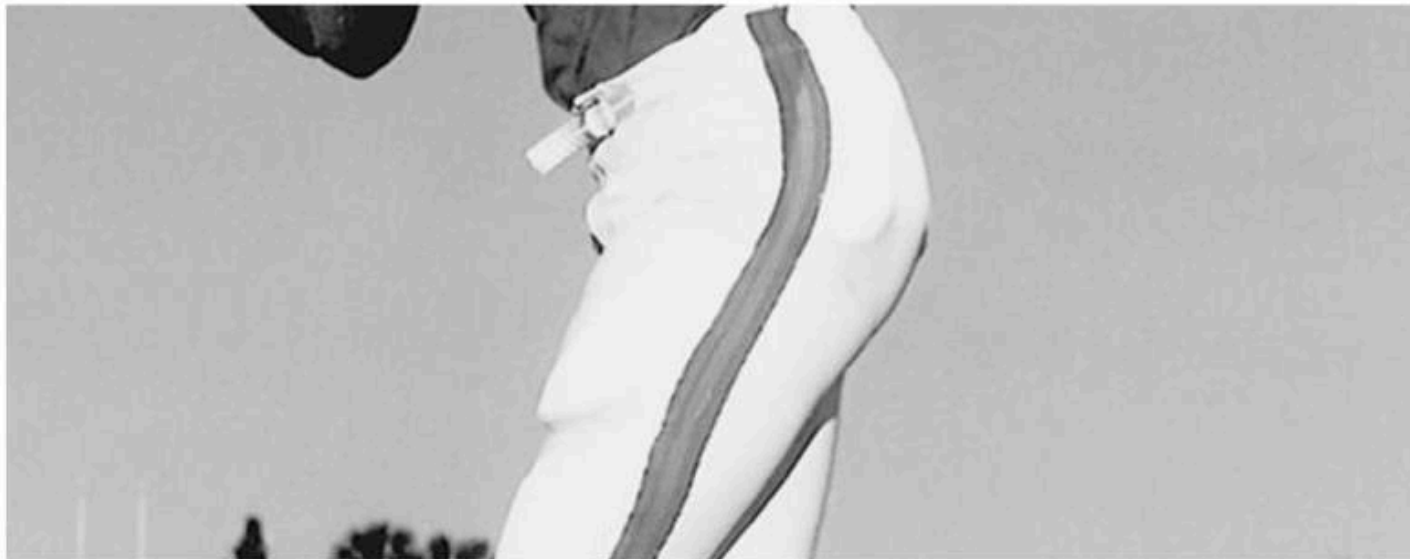
The Gators also learned Thursday that former receiver Chris Doering is their representative in the SEC's 2026 Football Legends class. The league named 16 former players and coaches, one for each school. South Carolina's honoree is receiver Sidney Rice.

Doering, a Gainesville native, played at Florida from 1991 to 1995. He finished with 149 catches for more than 2,000 yards and 31 touchdown receptions, a program record. As a senior in 1995, he caught 70 passes for 1,045 yards and 17 touchdowns and was a Second-Team AP All-American. He helped Florida win SEC titles from 1993 to 1995 and played 10 NFL seasons.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/gators-gamecocks-sells-out-doering-named-sec-legend

YOU CAN RESCHEDULE FOOTBALL. NOT A HURRICANE. BUT THE MEMORIES LINGER.

BY BUDDY MARTIN Oct. 7, 2026



Back in the day when Steve Spurrier started beating LSU in Baton Rouge (UAA Archive photo)

Bad weather in Tuscaloosa threatens big SEC game. But The Swamp?

By Buddy Martin

In the Southeastern Conference, we like to think we can handle just about anything.

Hostile crowds. Bad officiating. A fourth-and-one with the season on the line.

Hurricanes are another matter. They don't care about your national ranking, your kickoff time or how hard it is to find a hotel room in Baton Rouge. The initial forecast for Tuscaloosa and the Georgia-Alabama mega-game was looking so grim that there was some talk of moving it to Atlanta (although doubtful).

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/you-can-reschedule-football-not-a-hurricane-but-the-memories-linger

Fans can sometimes be seriously imperiled. I learned that lesson in 1964, with Joni beside me in a little Chevy Chevelle and both of us wondering whether we'd ever make it home.

Hurricane Hilda was bearing down on Louisiana, forcing the postponement of Florida's October 3 game at LSU. Football could wait.

Unfortunately, I decided we couldn't.

We had gotten caught in New Orleans and tried to drive back to Florida just as the hurricane was hitting. Let me offer my assessment of that decision, with the benefit of more than six decades of hindsight:

BAUGH OWNS IT: FLORIDA RUNNING BACK TEXTS SUMRALL AN APOLOGY AFTER MISSOURI LOSS

BY BRENDEN MARTIN Oct. 7, 2026

BAUGH OWNS IT

TEXTS SUMRALL AN APOLOGY

Jadan Baugh reached out the day after the 45-17 loss at Missouri.

GatorBait Media

Jadan Baugh did not wait for the film session. The day after Florida's 45-17 loss at Missouri, the Gators' running back sent coach Jon Sumrall a text message apologizing for his performance, ESPN reported.

"I'm sorry, coach. I won't let that happen again. I didn't play my best," Baugh wrote, according to ESPN's Mark Schlabach.

Baugh had been an early Heisman Trophy contender, running for 600 yards and 11 touchdowns during Florida's 4-0 start. Against Missouri he was held to 13 yards on 12 carries, ESPN reported. He gained 12 yards on his first carry and one yard on the other 11.

Sumrall shared the text at his Monday news conference and did not put the loss on his back alone.

"We didn't do enough to help him as a team on Saturday in my opinion, and I don't think he was his best either," Sumrall said. "I love Jadan because he owned it and he's ready to move forward."

Florida's running game managed 42 yards on 25 attempts against the Tigers, after gaining 302 yards in the Sept. 26 win over Ole Miss, ESPN reported. Sumrall called it the "most exposed" the offensive line has looked this season.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/baugh-owns-it-florida-running-back-texts-sumrall-an-apology-after-missouri-loss

THOUGHTS OF THE DAY: OCTOBER 7, 2026

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 7, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

A few thoughts to jump start your Wednesday morning:

Albert Einstein is credited with the quote, "Insanity is doing the same thing over and over again and expecting different results." Whether Einstein actually said it or not is debatable. What isn't debatable is Florida's defense, which keeps doing the same thing over and over again – allowing explosive plays of 10 or more yards. The Gators are 15th in the SEC and No. 95 nationally in explosive plays allowed – 67 of 10+ yards, 22 of 20+ yards, 11 of 30+, five of 40+, two each of plays netting more than 50, 60 and 70 yards, plus one 80-yard play.

The numbers are real and they prompted UF defensive coordinator Brad White to have one of those Captain Obvious moments Tuesday.

"We can't give up explosives both in the pass game and then in the run game," White said.

The Missouri game was the perfect example. The Gators (4-1, 2-1 SEC) gave up 560 yards and 45 points. Missouri ran for 220 yards, the first time the Gators had allowed more than 128 in a game all season. Mizzou had 34 carries that netted 63 yards (1.85 per carry). However, the Gators allowed runs of 77 and 80 yards on the other two carries. Missouri threw for 340 yards, averaging 11.3 yards per attempt. Mizzou, like the other teams, isn't beating the Gators with long bombs – only three plays all year have gone for 40 or more yards – but those intermediate range passes of 14-17 yards are killers because they loosen up the safeties, forcing them to play deeper while creating more space for receivers.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/thoughts-of-the-day-october-7-2026

BRENDEN MARTIN • NEWS

HOMEcoming TEST: NO. 16 FLORIDA HOSTS SOUTH CAROLINA SATURDAY AT 12:45 P.M.

BY BRENDEN MARTIN Oct. 7, 2026

SOUTH CAROLINA AT FLORIDA

SATURDAY, OCT. 10 • 12:45 P.M. ET

Homecoming at Ben Hill Griffin Stadium • SEC Network

GatorBait Media

No. 16 Florida (4-1, 2-1 SEC) gets its chance to answer the 45-17 loss at Missouri on Saturday, when South Carolina (2-3, 0-3 SEC) visits Ben Hill Griffin Stadium for Homecoming. Kickoff is 12:45 p.m. ET on SEC Network.

Florida opened as a 14.5-point favorite, according to ESPN's game preview.

THE MATCHUP, BY THE NUMBERS

Florida's offense averages 491.2 yards and 46.2 points per game, fifth in the FBS in scoring, ESPN's numbers show. The defense is the concern. It allows 393 yards per game (107th in the FBS), including 266.6 through the air (128th), and 27.2 points per game (104th). The Gators rank 27th in turnover margin at plus-4.

South Carolina averages 491 yards and 37.6 points per game and leans on the run. Its 256 rushing yards per game rank seventh in the FBS. Quarterback LaNorris Sellers has thrown for 1,059 yards and eight touchdowns with four interceptions, and Matthew Fuller leads the Gamecocks with 433 rushing yards on 71 carries. South Carolina is minus-6 in turnover margin, 130th in the FBS.

The Gamecocks come in off a 35-34 loss to Kentucky on Oct. 3. Sellers ran 17 times for 147 yards in that game, ESPN reported.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/homecoming-test-no-16-florida-hosts-south-carolina-saturday-at-12-45-p-m

THOUGHTS OF THE DAY: OCTOBER 6, 2026

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 6, 2026

THOUGHTS OF THE DAY

OCTOBER 6, 2026

Florida's loss, South Carolina, the polls and the SEC.

GatorBait Media

A few thoughts to jump start your Tuesday morning:

When asked if there is such a thing as a good loss, most often the competitive nature of coaches will compel them to say no, quite often with an expletive or two attached for emphasis. Truth is, there is a fine line between what can be categorized as a good loss and a bad one. If losing brings about a unified response with focus and intensity levels raised from top to bottom – head coach all the way down to the lowest manager on the team – then the loss might be looked on in the rearview mirror as a turning point. Coaches tend to like the concept of turning point better than admitting such a thing as a good loss.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/thoughts-of-the-day-october-6-2026

The loss to Missouri scraped all the luster off a 4-0 September that made the Florida Gators media darlings, that team straight out of nowhere streaking across the college football sky like a meteor. It only took a 45-17 pasting by Missouri to bring the Gators back down to earth. On Friday the Gators were the next big thing, a Cignetti-like clone ready to swashbuckle their way through the SEC and onto the College Football Playoff. By Saturday night, the debate was raging. Are the Gators contenders or are they pretenders?

BUDDY BLOG: FLORIDA GATORS NEED THE BALM OF HOMECOMING THIS WEEK

BY BUDDY MARTIN Oct. 5, 2026



GatorBait Media

Photo supplied by Buddy Martin; photo illustration.

Sumrall didn't care about Mizzou's homecoming, but he certainly does his own this week.

The scoreboard lied to Florida for four weeks. Missouri finally told the truth. **Jon Sumrall** said so himself Monday, in fewer words: "Plenty of that had already showed in previous outings, but it didn't cost us wins and losses."

There's your autopsy. The secondary leaked in September, and the run defense had soft spots. Nobody minded at 4-0 with a No. 8 ranking. Then came 45-17 in Columbia, and now the Gators are 4-1, No. 16 and in need of a hard look.

To his credit, Sumrall didn't blame the officials, the turf or the plane ride home.

"It starts with me," he said. "You have to tell yourself the truth, tell each other the truth, and own it."

It was refreshing to hear. It would be more refreshing to see.

"I've seen plenty of our downfalls through the first four weeks," he said. Good.

Somebody in the building was watching the tape while the rest of Gator Nation was pricing playoff hotels.

His fix was simple: "Really simple, we just gotta get better." Simple to say, anyway.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/buddy-blog-florida-gators-need-the-balm-of-homecoming-this-week

REELING GAMECOCKS, RATTLED GATORS: HOMECOMING COMES WITH A FIX LIST

BY BRENDEN MARTIN Oct. 5, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

Florida gets a week to show its first loss was a stumble and not the start of a slide. The homecoming opponent is a South Carolina team that is reeling even worse.

The Gators (4-1, 2-1 SEC) host the Gamecocks on Saturday, Oct. 10, after Missouri ran them off the field in Columbia. South Carolina (2-3, 0-3 SEC) is coming off a 35-34 overtime loss to No. 24 Kentucky. The Gamecocks led 17-0 early in the second quarter, and Kentucky won it with a 2-point pass in overtime, according to UK Athletics and the Lexington Herald-Leader's Kentucky.com.

On3's South Carolina site went further, writing that the loss "might be the breaking point for Shane Beamer at South Carolina." That is On3's opinion, not a reported decision, but it sums up the mood in Columbia, S.C.

Kickoff is set for 12:45 p.m. ET on SEC Network, the SEC announced Sunday, per floridagators.com. The loss cost Florida eight spots in the AP poll released Sunday, from No. 8 to No. 16, according to ESPN. Missouri climbed from No. 25 to No. 14.

FIX NO. 1: GET BAUGH ROOM TO RUN

Florida came to Missouri averaging 260 rushing yards a game and 5.9 yards a carry, per floridagators.com. It left with 42 yards on 25 carries, 1.7 a carry, per ESPN.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/reeling-gamecocks-rattled-gators-homecoming-comes-with-a-fix-list

FLORIDA GAVE ON SATURDAY. GAVE WAY TOO MUCH!

BY EDDIE GILLEY Oct. 5, 2026



GatorBait Media

The Florida Gators had it handed to them in Columbia on Saturday. They were whipped in every phase of the game. There is nothing you can point to where the Gators were better on Saturday.

Missouri had the answer for Florida's run game. Load the box. Commit to playing man coverage and a single safety on first down and dare the Gators to throw the ball. Florida kept trying to run the ball right into the teeth of the Tigers defense. It didn't go well. The Tigers held the Gators to less than a hundred yards gained on the ground. 42 total yards on the ground. Baugh had 13 yards on 12 carries!

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/florida-gave-on-saturday

The guy who led the nation in rushing touchdowns was kept out of the end zone on the first drive of the game and for the rest of the game as well. I thought the Gators would need to throw the ball to loosen up the run defense, but they just couldn't do it. The offensive line could not stand up against the basic rush of the Tigers. They were beaten up front all afternoon on rushes and passes.

MISSOURI 45, FLORIDA 17: POSTGAME ANALYSIS

BY LOREN MEADOWS Oct. 5, 2026



Photo illustration: GatorBait Media, from a Chris Spears file photo

Postgame Analysis: Florida Gators (4-1, 2-1) v. Missouri Tigers (4-1, 1-1)

Florida is humbled in Columbia as Sumrall faces his first week of adversity as Gator head coach.

By Loren Meadows, GatorBaitMedia.com Football Analyst,
Host of the Gator Lowdown with Loren Meadows

WHAT WE THOUGHT:

While the Gators have always struggled in Columbia since the addition of Missouri to the SEC, there was very little reason to think an offense that had averaged over 50 points per game and rushed for over three hundred yards a week ago would have any issues with a Missouri team that had missed over 50 tackles on the season. Missouri showed an inability to get the Mississippi State backs on the ground at key times, so **Jadan Baugh** and **Duke Clark** would be able to find running lanes despite Missouri stacking the box with a number of variable fronts.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/missouri-45-florida-17-postgame-analysis

Defensively, Florida had found a way to get enough stops and create enough turnovers to keep teams off balance, and a decent showing against Ole Miss had many thinking that the Gators were ready to turn the corner and begin to match an offense that had imposed their will against their opponents for four straight weeks. **Aaron Philo** looked poised to take the unit even higher as Buster Faulkner would prepare a gameplan to get his quarterback going in the face of the hostile CoMo crowd.

BEST SHOTS

From Florida 52, Ole Miss 28 · Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media



Into The Swamp



Open field



The defense swarms



Baugh at the goal line



End-zone corner

Next up: Texas in Austin, Oct. 17. Then an open date before Georgia in Atlanta on Oct. 31.

GatorBait Magazine, Friday Pregame Edition, Friday, October 9, 2026. Independent Florida Gators coverage. ESPN game summary (event 401858714) and DraftKings line as of Oct. 8, 2026; NWS Jacksonville forecast, Oct. 8; South Carolina game notes, flip card and SEC Week 6 release. The line and forecast can move before Saturday. Published by GatorBait Media, www.gatorbaitmedia.com.